

SSH & Tailscale VPN Complete Setup Guide

OpenClaw Masterclass — Server Security & Remote Access

What you'll set up in this guide:

- SSH access to your VPS from your own computer
- Tailscale VPN for secure private networking
- Password-less SSH through Tailscale
- Hostinger firewall to block unauthorized access
- SSH tunnels to access dashboards in your browser

This guide is for VPS users (e.g. Hostinger). If you're running OpenClaw locally on your own computer, you don't need SSH, firewall, or port forwarding — you already have direct access to everything. The only part that may be useful for local users is installing Tailscale if you want to access your agent from your phone or other devices when you're away from your computer.

Quick Reference — All Commands

Task	Command
SSH into server (with password)	<code>ssh root@SERVER_IP</code>
SSH via Tailscale (no password)	<code>ssh root@TAILSCALE_IP</code>
Install Tailscale on server	<code>curl -fsSL https://tailscale.com/install.sh sh</code>
Start Tailscale with SSH	<code>tailscale up --ssh</code>
Check connected devices	<code>tailscale status</code>

List Docker containers	<code>docker ps</code>
Enter Docker container	<code>docker exec -it CONTAINER_ID /bin/bash</code>
Check OpenClaw status	<code>openclaw status</code>
Check gateway port	<code>openclaw gateway</code>
SSH tunnel (port forward)	<code>ssh -N -L PORT:127.0.0.1:PORT root@TAILSCALE_IP</code>
Exit container or server	<code>exit</code>

Part 1: SSH Into Your Server

SSH (Secure Shell) lets you control your server remotely from your own computer's terminal. Your server is running in a data centre — SSH is how you get inside it and run commands.

Method 1: Hostinger Browser Terminal

The quickest way to access your server. No setup needed.

Step 1: Go to your Hostinger VPS dashboard

Step 2: Click the Terminal button

Step 3: You're in — logged in as root

Method 2: SSH From Your Own Computer

More control and faster than the browser terminal.

Step 1: Open Terminal on your computer

- **Mac:** Search for Terminal in Spotlight (Cmd + Space)
- **Windows:** Search for Terminal or Command Prompt

Step 2: Find your server IP and root password

Both are on your Hostinger VPS dashboard overview page. You can reset the root password from there if needed.

Step 3: Connect via SSH

```
ssh root@YOUR_SERVER_IP
```

Step 4: First-time connection — type yes when asked about authenticity

Step 5: Enter your root password

Important: When typing your password, nothing will appear on screen — no dots, no asterisks. This is normal. Just paste it and hit Enter. On Mac use Cmd+V, on Windows right-click to paste.

Accessing OpenClaw Inside Docker

OpenClaw runs inside a Docker container. Commands like **openc1aw** only work inside the container, not on the server directly.

Step	Command	What it does
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1	<code>docker ps</code>	Lists running containers — find the container ID
2	<code>docker exec -it CONTAINER_ID /bin/bash</code>	Gets you inside the container
3	<code>openclaw status</code>	Shows agent status, channels, model info
4	<code>openclaw gateway</code>	Shows the gateway port number
5	<code>exit</code>	Leaves the container (back to server)
6	<code>exit</code>	Leaves the server (back to your computer)

How to Read the `docker ps` Output

When you run `docker ps`, you'll see something like this:

```
CONTAINER ID IMAGE PORTS
e336d285de7c ghcr.io/.../openclaw:latest 0.0.0.0:61072->61072/tcp
```

- **CONTAINER ID** — the first column (e.g. `e336d285de7c`). Copy this and use it in the `docker exec` command.
- **PORTS** — shows the exposed port number (e.g. `61072`). This is the port you use in your SSH tunnel command and in your browser URL.

Important: The port shown by `openclaw gateway` inside the container (e.g. 18789) may be different from the port in the PORTS column of `docker ps` (e.g. 61072). Always use the `docker ps` port for SSH tunnels and browser access.

Part 2: Installing Tailscale VPN

Tailscale creates a private network between your devices. After setup, only your authorized devices can reach the server. Everyone else is blocked.

Step 1: Install Tailscale on Your Server

Make sure you're SSH'd into your server, then run:

```
curl -fsSL https://tailscale.com/install.sh | sh
```

Step 2: Start Tailscale with SSH Support

```
tailscale up --ssh
```

The **--ssh** flag enables password-less SSH through Tailscale.

Step 3: Authenticate

- Copy the URL that appears in the terminal
- Open it in your browser
- Sign in with Google, Microsoft, or another provider
- Click **Connect** to authorize the device
- Terminal should show **Success**

Important: Use a secure account with a strong password. This is what protects your server — anyone with access to this account can access your server.

Step 4: Install Tailscale on Your Computer

- Go to **tailscale.com** and download for your OS
- Install and run the app
- Sign in with the **same account** you used on the server
- Click **Connect**

Mac users: You may see two popups: one asking to add VPN configurations (click **Allow**) and one for System Extension approval (click **Open Settings**, find Tailscale Network Extension, enable the toggle).

Step 5: Verify Both Devices Are Connected

On the server, run:

```
tailscale status
```

You should see both your computer and your server listed with IP addresses starting with **100**.

Step 6: Find Your Server's Tailscale IP

You can find it in three ways:

- From **tailscale status** output on the server
- Tailscale admin console at login.tailscale.com
- Tailscale app on your computer → **Network Devices** → click server to copy IP

Step 7: SSH Via Tailscale (No Password!)

```
ssh root@YOUR_TAILSCALE_IP
```

Replace YOUR_TAILSCALE_IP with the IP starting with 100. You should get in **without typing a password** because Tailscale already verified your device.

Part 3: Hostinger Firewall

Tailscale provides software-level protection. The firewall adds server-level protection — a second layer that blocks any traffic that isn't coming through Tailscale.

Setup Steps:

1. Go to Hostinger VPS dashboard → **Security** → **Firewall**
2. Create a new firewall (name it anything, e.g. "tailscale")
3. Turn it on
4. Click **Edit** and add this rule:

Action	Protocol	Port	Source
Accept	UDP	41641	Anywhere

5. Click **Synchronise** to apply

That's it — one rule. No SSH port 22, nothing else. The only way in is through Tailscale.

Part 4: SSH Tunnels (Port Forwarding)

SSH tunnels let you access things running on your server (like the gateway dashboard or Mission Control) directly in your browser, securely through Tailscale.

Finding the Correct Port

Before creating a tunnel, you need to know which port to forward. There are two ways to find it:

Method 1: From inside the Docker container

```
openclaw gateway
```

Method 2: From the server (outside the container)

```
docker ps
```

Look at the **PORTS** column — this shows the actual port exposed on the server.

Important: On Hostinger with Docker, the port shown by **openclaw gateway** inside the container (e.g. 18789) may be different from the port Docker exposes on the outside (e.g. 61072). Always check **docker ps** for the actual exposed port. Use the **docker ps** port in your tunnel command.

Creating the Tunnel

Open a **new terminal** (keep it open as long as you need the tunnel) and run:

```
ssh -N -L PORT:127.0.0.1:PORT root@YOUR_TAILSCALE_IP
```

Replace **PORT** with the actual port from **docker ps** and **YOUR_TAILSCALE_IP** with your server's Tailscale IP.

Part	Meaning
-N	No remote commands — just the tunnel
-L PORT:127.0.0.1:PORT	Forward server's PORT to your localhost PORT
root@TAILSCALE_IP	Connect through Tailscale's secure network

Opening in Your Browser

Once the tunnel is running (terminal stays silent — that's normal), open your browser and go to:

```
http://127.0.0.1:PORT
```

You may need your **gateway token** to log in. Find it in Hostinger Docker Manager under environment variables.

Tip: The tunnel stays open as long as the terminal window is open. Close the terminal = close the tunnel. Just run the command again when you need it.

For Local Users: Tailscale Setup

If you're running OpenClaw locally on your own computer, you don't need SSH, firewall, or port forwarding. You can skip Parts 1-4 entirely. But if you want to access your agent from your phone or another device when you're not at your computer, follow these steps to set up Tailscale.

Step 1: Install Tailscale on your computer

- Go to **tailscale.com** and download for your OS (Mac, Windows, or Linux)
- Install and open the app
- Sign in with Google, Microsoft, or another provider
- Click **Connect**

Mac users: You may see a popup asking to add VPN configurations — click **Allow**. You may also need to approve the System Extension in Settings > General > Login Items & Extensions.

Step 2: Install Tailscale on your phone

- Download Tailscale from the App Store (iPhone) or Google Play (Android)
- Sign in with the **same account** you used on your computer
- Tap **Connect**

Step 3: Verify both devices are connected

Open the Tailscale app on either device. You should see both your computer and your phone listed with IP addresses starting with **100**.

Step 4: Access your agent from your phone

If OpenClaw is running a dashboard or web app on your computer (e.g. Mission Control on port 3007), you can now access it from your phone's browser by going to:

```
http://YOUR_COMPUTER_TAILSCALE_IP:PORT
```

Replace YOUR_COMPUTER_TAILSCALE_IP with the Tailscale IP of your computer (the one starting with 100) and PORT with whatever port the app is running on. No SSH tunnel needed — Tailscale connects your devices directly.

That's it for local users. You can now access your agent's dashboards from any device on your Tailscale network, even when you're not at home.

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Troubleshooting

Problem	Solution
SSH says 'access denied'	Check password — no extra spaces. Reset root password from Hostinger dashboard if needed.
SSH via Tailscale hangs	Check Tailscale is connected (toggle in menu bar / system tray). Check tailscale status on server.
Tailscale asks for verification URL	Normal for new terminal sessions. Open the link, approve, and the connection will complete.
'openclaw' command not found	You're on the server, not inside the Docker container. Use docker exec to get inside first.
Browser shows 'connection refused' after tunnel	Wrong port. Run docker ps on the server and check the PORTS column for the actual exposed port.
Mac: Tailscale VPN popup	Click Allow. Then approve System Extension in Settings > General > Login Items & Extensions.

Tunnel stopped working	The terminal running the tunnel was probably closed. Open it again and re-run the <code>ssh -N -L</code> command.
Can't find Tailscale icon on Mac	Open Spotlight (Cmd + Space), type Tailscale, open the app. Icon may be hidden if menu bar is crowded.

What You've Achieved

- ✓ SSH access to your server from your own terminal
- ✓ Tailscale VPN creating a private network between your devices
- ✓ Password-less SSH through Tailscale
- ✓ Hostinger firewall blocking all unauthorized traffic
- ✓ SSH tunnels to access gateway and dashboards from your browser
- ✓ Knowledge of Docker commands to access OpenClaw inside the container

Your server is now locked down and only accessible from your authorized devices. This is the foundation for everything that comes next — including building your Mission Control dashboard.